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C L A S S I C L I T E R A T U R E

A Subway
At AIIMS

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Udhav Saraswat

*“Sooner or later, we all understand
that the world repeats the same
stories. It is we who present them
differently.”*

— Udhav

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Chapter 1: The Quiet Beginning

The school bell started ringing, pulling me out of the half-sleep I had been floating in during the last few lectures. All I wanted was to get out of the classroom. Not because home was calling me, but because a cricket match was waiting right after school. A group of ten friends had fixed it in advance, and no matter how hot the sun burned, our dedication at that age didn't care. Heat, sweat, exhaustion — nothing mattered.

For the past few days, though, I had been losing match after match. I knew I needed more practice, but evening tuition classes stole whatever time and energy I had left. By the time I finished dinner at night, I could barely keep my eyes open long enough to imagine playing better the next day. My days ended with stress, and mornings started like a battle I had to prepare for again and again.

There was a girl in my class who always sat on the front bench. Light brown hair, a round face, timid eyes — but sharp enough to make me feel like I had done something wrong every time she looked at me. Sometimes she stared at me with such intensity

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that it felt like she was trying to kill me with her eyes. Typical first-bencher: studious, disciplined, the teacher's favourite.

We had never talked. And honestly, with the way she looked at me, I wasn't sure I ever could.

Some classmates once joked that she liked me. But with those death stares, I could barely stand in front of her without my heart racing — I've never been good with fast bowlers anyway, so I did what I always do: let that ball go untouched.

Years passed. I completed my 12th, and like every batch that eventually scatters, all of us moved to different cities, different careers, different lives. Barely a few stayed in touch. And with the personality I have, I hardly manage to keep people close for long. Sooner or later, I get consumed by the chaos of my own world, leaving contacts buried under time.

I chose engineering and did well in it. Won medals too. My quiet, boring personality turned out to be good for something — it gave me plenty of time to focus on my career. After graduation, I got a software development job at an MNC. I poured myself into my work the same way I once poured myself into cricket, and in a few years, that dedication paid off.

Last year, I met a girl online through someone I knew. I messaged her casually, and slowly we became good friends. We played games, joked around, kept in touch from time to time — a simple bond, but a pleasant one. And only after a while did I discover the truth: she was the same girl who used to scare me in school — Supriya.

Chapter 1: The Quiet Beginning

Recently, she had been away for a while. I wondered what was going on and finally messaged her. She replied that she wasn't doing well in life.

I grew curious. I kept asking my usual never-ending questions. Her replies were slow, distant. I thought maybe she was busy with someone else, maybe dating, maybe just tired. I never imagined anything serious. I don't know why, but her voice, her name, her way of talking had always felt different to me — something I had never experienced before.

And then one day, she called me suddenly.

Her voice was weak, trembling. She told me her reports had shown Stage 3 abdominal cancer — a rare type, difficult to treat. My mind went blank. I couldn't understand how or why it happened. But life never gives reasons for everything.

She sounded exhausted. I could feel her struggling even to speak. I quickly asked for the hospital details before she hung up, telling me the doctor had arrived.

After the call, I sat silently, shocked and helpless. All I could think about — day and night — was going to see her. As soon as possible.

Something inside me shifted in that moment. And I didn't know then... this was just the beginning.

Chapter 2: Not a Date, But the First One

When I walked into the ICU, I froze. It was the first time I saw her sleeping — really saw her after years. Something inside me shifted. I had never felt anything like it before. She looked familiar, almost painfully familiar, like someone I had known forever even though I was seeing her for the first time in my conscious memory.

Her face was pale, but there was a strange warmth in it, as if she had been waiting for me long before I even arrived. I caught myself wondering how beautiful her eyes might be when they opened.

While I was lost in that thought, I noticed her mother sitting on the small sofa beside the bed. Alone. Quiet. The kind of silence that tells you life is a battle you often fight by yourself. A part of me — I don't know from where — wished I could be a small part of that battle.

The air in that room was heavy. Heavy enough that I felt breathless, unable to speak or ask anything. It felt like time had

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paused, like I was standing inside a moment I wasn't prepared for. If I could have taken her pain into away, I would have done it without a second thought.

I finally walked closer. Her mother gestured for me to sit. I handed her the water bottle lying lifeless on the table. She took a sip, but even that felt too heavy for her. She didn't know me well, yet her eyes held a strange familiarity — like she had met a version of me somewhere before.

When I hugged her, I whispered, "Everything is going to be okay." Even though inside, I was just as helpless as she was.

A single tear fell from her eye and landed directly on my chest, right above my heart. I swear my heartbeat stumbled for a second. But I stayed strong — or at least pretended to.

After a while, she slowly opened her eyes. And just as I had imagined — they were beautiful. A little red from weakness, but shining. Like her soul hadn't given up.

"Finally you came to see me," she said softly.

"Did you think I wouldn't?" I replied.

She looked away. "It's hard to expect anything from people now. We've only known each other online. Why would someone care for me in this state?"

For a moment, I couldn't speak. The world really has changed that much — people don't expect care anymore.

She waited patiently for my answer.

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To lighten the moment, I said, “Actually, I feel like I’m not even from this world. Maybe from some other planet.”

She laughed — the same laugh I’d heard during our voice calls. Loud, free, and strangely comforting. Her smile was the most weirdly beautiful thing I had seen in a long time. I kept staring, which made her instantly hide it, thinking maybe her condition made me uncomfortable.

I shook my head lightly. “A smile like yours shouldn’t be hidden. The world would feel empty without it.”

She relaxed a little.

Then she asked, “Have you been missing me these days?”

How could I tell her that the sky I stared at every night made me more restless than I thought I am, thinking about her!

I said, “What is there to miss when you’re right in front of me now?”

Her lips trembled slightly. “That day might not always come... you know.”

I smiled softly. “One of the gods is my friend. I’ll ask her to make this forever.”

She blinked at me. “Will they listen to you?”

“They always do,” I said. “It’s not my first time asking them. They always do.”

She smiled — a fragile, hopeful smile. Even if it wouldn’t last forever, at least she saw someone wishing for her in a world

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where most people only wish for themselves.

She might have liked me — I knew that. But distance had created small gaps between us. Even then, from the very beginning, I had felt something for her. And I was smart enough to know love isn't something that happens in a moment or a dream.

But then why did this feel so different?

I had brought flowers and a chocolate for her.

"These are for you," I said.

She smiled. "Thank you... flowers are okay, but chocolates aren't allowed."

"Oh," I said. "Then I'll have to find someone else for them."

She burst out laughing. "Seriously! You'll never change."

"Oh, so you don't like me the way I am?" I teased.

She shook her head softly. "You're the best soul I've met. Maybe God wanted me to meet you before I go."

My heart stopped for a moment.

"Now that I've met you," I said, "do you think I'll let you go?"

She felt awkward — her mother was still in the room — so I quickly corrected myself.

"I mean... aunty won't let you go, right?"

She smiled a bit, and the moment turned normal again.

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I wanted to kiss her forehead — just a small kiss — but it felt too soon, especially with her mother sitting right there. I don't usually care about anything when I'm in love, but honestly, love has tested me enough to make me question my own philosophies.

The hospital was average — clean but small. Her father worked as a bank employee in West Delhi. Their earnings were enough for a decent life, but big hospitals charge in a way that doesn't just fail to save the one admitted... they slowly kill the ones paying. I wasn't very different. Just another middle-class guy working as a software developer. I earned okay, but my ambitions kept growing, often making even the sky feel low.

Then the doctor walked in.

"That's enough for today. She needs rest. She has chemo tomorrow."

Her eyes instantly filled with fear — and hope, both at the same time. Hope that I'd come again. Fear that I might not.

I held her hands gently and said, "Everything will be fine. I told you... I'll come again."

She nodded.

As I walked out, her mother accompanied me to the exit.

I looked at her and asked, "Is there anything I can do?"

"We don't need anything right now, she will be moved to AIIMS tomorrow for better treatment, you can visit often" she said softly. "But you coming today... it made her truly happy. We haven't seen her smile like that in a long time."

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I nodded. “I will.”

And with that, I left the hospital for the day — carrying her tear, her smile, and her fear inside my chest, like they all belonged to me.

Chapter 3: The Unknown Storyteller

Days passed, and she was getting a little better, though it was hard to say anything with certainty. I hadn't been able to visit her for a week, but I stayed in touch with her mother, asking about every little change, every bit of progress.

It was Saturday — a day that didn't demand much from me. I decided I had to see her. I brought flowers again, but no chocolate this time. Instead, I picked up a juice, hoping this one wouldn't require a "Plan B" recipient.

I took an auto to Noida City Centre Metro Station, switched between a few lines, and finally reached AIIMS.

Above the main road near the station, there's a long pedestrian subway bridge — about the height of a five-storey building. From up there, you can see one of the busiest stretches of Delhi, a never-ending river of vehicles flowing day and night.

I had spent hours on that bridge before... just standing, watching the chaos below. It calmed me in a strange way — people

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rushing, people waiting, people arguing with autorickshaw drivers, people booking cabs — everyone going somewhere.

And then there was me, standing alone, not rushing anywhere.

That's where I met Prakash.

We bumped into each other randomly. A thin guy, maybe in his early twenties, with a smile that somehow refused to fade. He told me he had lost both his parents when he was eight. He ran a small tea stall nearby and sometimes sat on the subway bridge when he got tired.

There was a quiet honesty in his voice.

He spoke about how his father suffered from a liver disease, how they waited endlessly for a bed at AIIMS. He talked about long waiting lists, endless queues of patients, and how only people with contacts or influence managed to get treatment on time. His father eventually got a bed — but too late. Too late for recovery, and too expensive for hope.

The sadness in his eyes wasn't the kind that asked for pity. It was the kind that had learned to live with itself.

I felt the heaviness of his story.

In return, I told him about Supriya — her health, her struggle, my fear.

Despite his own pain, he patted my back and said, "Things will get better. People say there is a God above the clouds... and a pure heart like yours will get his attention."

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I didn't know whether he believed what he said. I didn't know whether I believed it either. But somehow, his words calmed me.

It was almost 6 in the evening. The bridge was empty except for the two of us. I turned for a moment, then asked him where his tea stall was — I told him I'd visit for a cup of tea.

I turned back.

He was gone.

Just like that.

He hadn't walked away — I would've heard footsteps. There were no exits nearby. No other people on the bridge.

He had simply... disappeared.

A cold shiver ran down my spine. But I was getting late, so I rushed toward the hospital.

She looked better that day.

Her room was 604. She was alone, sitting by the window, watching kids play in the garden below. The moment she saw me, her eyes brightened.

"Mr. Busy Guy, you're back," she teased.

"Yes," I smiled. "Where's your mother today?"

"She'll be back in an hour. Went home to get food for me."

"You could've told me. I know how to cook too. I would've made something for you."

She laughed softly. “Really? You want to make me more sick?”

“You doubt my cooking skills?”

“Of course. I’ve never tasted anything you’ve made.”

I shrugged. “I never got the chance to cook for you.”

She smiled. “Next time, bring rajma. That’s my favourite. You know how to make it?”

“In theory, yes,” I said. “My spices go up and down sometimes... but there are tutorials for emergencies.”

She gave me a playful stare. “So you’ll experiment your cooking skills on me?”

“Why not?”

We laughed together, just looking at each other — a calm moment in the middle of all the chaos.

“I brought juice today,” I said.

“Oh? You’ve really been thinking about what to bring, haven’t you?”

“Yes,” I said quietly. “Anything to make my friend feel better.”

“I don’t know why,” she whispered, “but hearing that... I already feel better.”

“I’m glad my visits help,” I said. “Honestly, I could stay here all night.”

“And office? Isn’t work hectic?” she asked.

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“It’s been years doing this job. I’ll manage.”

“So sweet of you,” she said. “But not needed. My mother will be here.”

“Okay,” I smiled. “But I’ll always be a thought away.”

She rolled her eyes. “Don’t use your flirty lines again. What will you even do after impressing me now?”

“Oh... so you’re not impressed yet? Looks like I’ll have to work a little harder now.”

She laughed. “Very funny. You never miss a chance.”

“If it’s for you, then I won’t.”

A little later, her mother returned. She was genuinely happy to see me again. I greeted her and stepped out so Supriya could eat and rest.

It was around 8 PM. I thought of grabbing a cup of tea and maybe finding Prakash’s stall. I searched nearby, asked around, but no one had heard of him. No tea stall matched his description. No one even knew anyone named Prakash in that area.

When I mentioned meeting him on the subway bridge, one man said:

“Everything that happens on that subway isn’t real. That bridge has seen and absorbed so much pain... it creates its own stories, its own people.”

I stood there, stunned.

Chapter 3: The Unknown Storyteller

Was Prakash even real? Who was he? Where did he disappear in seconds? Was his story true... or just another echo from that strange bridge?

With those questions swirling in my mind, I headed back home.

Chapter 4: The End of the Story?

A week later, while I was getting ready for work, my phone rang. It was Supriya's mother. She rarely called, and never without a reason. The moment I saw her name, something inside me tightened.

I picked up immediately.

Her voice was shaking. "Something has gone wrong... the doctors said her condition suddenly collapsed. They... they don't know how long she has."

I couldn't respond for a few seconds.

"But she was doing better," I said softly. "She was improving."

"I don't know what happened," she whispered. "They're trying, but her body isn't responding anymore."

My heart sank.

"I'm coming right now," I said, already grabbing my keys.

Chapter 4: The End of the Story?

The ride to the hospital felt endless. I don't remember the roads or the traffic — just the fear that kept building in my chest.

When I reached her floor, her mother was waiting in the corridor. Her hands were trembling, her eyes swollen from crying.

"She's inside," she said quietly.

I walked into the room.

Supriya was lying still, looking more fragile than I had ever seen her. Her face looked calm, but in a way that scared me. The machines were beeping in slow, uneven intervals.

I pulled a chair closer and held her hand. It was cold.

"Hey," I whispered, "I'm here."

She didn't respond. Her breathing was shallow and slow. The pauses between each breath felt longer and heavier.

"I thought you were getting better," I whispered. "There was still so much you had to say... and I still had so much to ask."

Her mother stood behind me, quietly crying.

The doctor came in, checked the monitor, and sighed.

"I'm sorry," he said softly. "Her body isn't responding anymore."

He left the room.

Time felt like it had stopped. I kept talking to her even though she couldn't hear me. Her breathing grew weaker.

Then it slowed.

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And then it stopped.

A nurse came in, checked her, and looked at us gently.

“She’s gone.”

The words didn’t feel real. It was like the world had shifted and refused to settle back.

A tear rolled down my face before I even realized it. It felt like something inside me had cracked open.

Her mother sank into a chair, crying, and I held her because there was nothing else to do.

Later, we took Supriya home. Her room still felt like her — the books, the neatly folded scarf, the little things she used every day. Everything felt heavier than before.

The next morning, after the rituals, people came to offer condolences and left. And slowly, over the hours, it felt like Supriya drifted from this world to wherever she was meant to go.

When her ashes settled, I whispered to myself, “I hope you’re free now. And if there’s something beyond this... I hope you can still hear me.”

I don’t know if she could.

But I wanted to believe she did.

There was a song of backstreet boys I loved years ago, one that slipped out of my memory with time. I didn’t understand it back then. But today, every word feels like it was written for me.

“Show me the meaning of being lonely

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Is this the feeling I need to walk with?

Tell me why I can't be there where you are

There's something missing in my heart

Life goes on as it never ends

Eyes of stone observe the trends

They never say, forever gaze, if only

Beauty roams to an endless love

There's no control, are you with me now?

Walk with me and maybe

Nights of light so soon become

Wild and free, I could feel the sun

Your every wish will be done.

They tell me..”

Chapter 5: The Never-Ending Love

Few years have passed.

Life has changed in ways I never imagined, yet some things have stayed exactly the same — untouched, almost sacred. Once every year, on the same quiet afternoon, I visit Supriya's mother. We sit together on her small balcony, two cups of tea slowly growing cold between us. She tells me stories about her daughter — the tiny memories, the habits, the moments she still holds close. And every time, I listen with the same stillness, as though hearing them for the very first time.

In those moments, neither of us tries to fill the silence. We simply let Supriya be there with us, the way she always has.

My own life kept moving too. I got married last year. My wife understands more than she ever says. She knows a part of me is tied to a chapter she can never enter, and she never tries to.

We have a daughter now.

Her name is Supriya.

Chapter 5: The Never-Ending Love

It wasn't a decision made from memory or longing. It just felt gentle... natural. A quiet way of honoring the girl who once changed something inside me. My wife agreed to the name before I even finished saying it. Maybe she understood without needing words.

My daughter is nothing like the Supriya I knew, but sometimes, when she laughs suddenly or thinks deeply with her head slightly tilted, something inside me pauses — not with sadness, but with gratitude. Life returns warmth to places we once thought would always remain cold.

I still have a photograph of Supriya — one I took quietly in the hospital. It has stayed in my suitcase all these years, hidden from everyone. Some nights, I open the suitcase and talk to her, asking how she's doing in her own world now, don't know which world she belongs to now.

Maybe she isn't in this world anymore... but she's with me, and she'll stay alive as long as I do.

Summary

“A Subway at AIIMS” follows the quiet, reflective journey of a young man who reconnects—almost accidentally—with an old classmate, Supriya, years after school. What starts as casual online friendship becomes a profound emotional bond when he discovers she is battling a rare and aggressive cancer.

Their connection deepens through small conversations, fragile laughter, and unspoken feelings shared in the hospital’s silence. As he visits her in AIIMS, he finds himself confronting truths about care, love, helplessness, and the strange ways two lives can collide at the wrong time, yet still mean everything.

He also meets Prakash — a mysterious stranger on a subway bridge outside AIIMS — whose sudden disappearance leaves him questioning fate, destiny, and the unseen forces surrounding places filled with so much human suffering.

When Supriya’s condition suddenly collapses, he rushes to be with her in her final moments. Her death leaves behind a quiet but permanent imprint on him — a grief that softens rather than hardens him.

Ten years later, his life has moved forward: a marriage, a daughter, a new chapter. But a part of him still keeps Supriya alive — in memories, in conversations with her photograph hidden in his suitcase, and in the understanding that some people

Summary

remain with us even after they've gone. He visits her mother every year, sharing silence, tea, and the warmth of remembering someone who mattered.

Supriya's story doesn't end with her death; it becomes part of how he lives.

Philisophical Takeaways

1. Some stories end early, but their meaning doesn't. Supriya's life was short, but it shaped him for decades. Not all love stays, but all love changes us.
2. People don't leave — they shift form inside us. She exists now as memory, warmth, tenderness, and the part of him that knows how to care deeply.
3. Love isn't defined by duration, but by depth. He met her late, lost her early, and still found a lifetime's worth of emotion in between.
4. Some strangers appear only to guide us. Prakash — real or not — represented those inexplicable moments in life where help arrives from places we never understand.
5. Life continues, but it never erases what mattered. Time doesn't heal everything. It just teaches us how to live with tenderness instead of pain.
6. The world repeats the same stories — but we live them differently. Just like the opening quote, the book shows how love, loss, and memory happen to everyone — but the experience is uniquely ours.